

Module 7

Digital Marketing

Podcast Transcript

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Preliminary Note

In this podcast, I introduce you to digital marketing. The transcript of this podcast is also shared with you (see below), as indicated in the syllabus. This transcript allows you to focus even more on the podcast (and hence listen attentively) and to thus grasp the essence of it. This transcript is brought to you in a Word document, such that you can choose if and how you process this text during studying.

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1. Welcome & Introduction

Good morning, good afternoon, good evening, or maybe even good night – whenever you're tuning in. Welcome to this podcast! My name is Tine De Bock, and I'm a Professor of Marketing at KU Leuven. In this podcast, we're diving into a crucial topic that no marketer can afford to ignore: digital marketing. I want to break down digital marketing into its key aspects and help you understand why it's such a game-changer.

So, let's get started with an important question. Digital marketing: you obviously hear the word “digital” in there, but what exactly do we mean by that? What exactly do we mean by “digital”? That's actually a great question to start with. I'm not going to look up a dictionary definition, and I'm also not going to explain it from an IT perspective. Instead, I will approach it from my own field, being marketing.

Digital, that means technologies. And when you say technologies, two things come to mind. First, technologies enable new business models. Second, technologies means lots and lots of data being generated.

3. New Business Models & the Role of Data

Ok, so new business models on the one hand. And an abundance of data on the other hand. Let's zoom in on that first aspect: new business models. New business models mean that marketing itself is changing because we have new ways to interact with customers. Let me give you some specific examples, because that always makes things clearer. Take chatbots, for instance. Instead of calling a customer service line, you can now chat with an automatic tool on a website. And that chatbot might even help you make a reservation at a restaurant or a hotel. Or think of delivery services—instead of someone on a scooter delivering your pizza, a drone might drop it off at your door. Another example: e-bikes and shared mobility services. Maybe you've used one before. You open an app, locate a bike, and ride it wherever you need to go. But that app also collects a lot of data—it tracks where customers pick up and drop off bikes, when they use them, and so on. It's essentially a digital platform connecting people to products. And of course, we all know Airbnb. That also started as a new platform, connecting customers to service providers in new ways, made possible by technology. Or what about self-driving taxis? A car equipped with sensors, eliminating the need for a driver. And finally, a very relevant and maybe simple example: instead of traditional TV commercials, brands are now working with social media influencers—people who promote products like watches, shoes, clothing, or even cars to thousands or millions of followers on social media.

So when you have a look at how business can be different because of these new technologies, it's important to realize that it's so much more than just the internet. Digital marketing entails also so much more than having a website on which people can order online, or it's more than being present on social media platforms such as Facebook. Digital marketing is so much more due to these new technologies. And again, these technologies change the way we interact or

can interact with customers.

Ok, so this was the first aspect that I wanted to mention, new business models emerging. But there is a second aspect that is important to mention when we talk about digital, and remember, that's data. Those technologies also come with a huge amount of data. There is a huge amount of data available through digital platforms, something we were already somewhat familiar with. For example, if you have a loyalty card, whether for a supermarket or another store, a lot of data is collected about you. But today, this data is no longer limited to those loyalty cards. For example, you might be connected to a company through an app—that also collects data. Or it could be website data: how do people navigate to a website? Through which channels? Why do they spend more time on certain pages? We try to analyze why people do or do not make a purchase on our webpage, and so on. Or it could be something very simple: free marketing data. In the past, if you wanted to know what your customers thought of you, you had to actively approach them. That is, of course, still useful today, but now, a huge amount of data is available for free. Think about all those blogs and review sites, like Tripadvisor. If you're in that industry—if you own a hotel, for example—it's incredibly easy to find out what people think about you: what they like, what they don't like, but also what they think about your competitors. And all of that information is available for free.

And what is of course very interesting is that we can apply data analysis techniques to all this information. There are so many tools available, like text mining. This means we can analyze the text that customers write in blogs and forums using sentiment analysis techniques: what emotions do we see? Is the sentiment more positive or negative? And the great thing is, these tools are often times freely available online, so the possibilities with data are enormous. It's not just about having data, but also about how we can use that data, or how it is collected through all these new tools. These apps, robots, and other technologies can thus provide us with new insights, which is incredibly valuable.

So, in a nutshell... digital marketing includes the word 'digital'. That refers to technologies. And if we talk about technologies, we first of all talk about new business models and, secondly, about richness of data.

4. Is Digital Marketing Different From Regular Marketing?

But in digital marketing is also the word 'marketing'. And so one might wonder, is digital marketing something different than just marketing (without the digital in it)? Again an important question to address. You know, I'm sometimes surprised when I ask people: "What do you think is the difference between digital marketing and marketing?" Many assume they are completely different, but in reality, they share the same fundamental goal. Marketing, at its core, is about creating value for the customer. And digital marketing is simply a way to achieve that goal using new tools, data-driven insights, personalized offers, technology, and so on. Take the example of a smart fridge. The goal of digital marketing is not just to analyze data. It's about enhancing the customer experience—suggesting recipes based on what's inside, reminding them when food is about to expire, or even automating their grocery list. So, the

essence of marketing and digital marketing is the same. Digital marketing simply helps us do marketing better—but it doesn't change its ultimate purpose: to create value and satisfy customers.

5. Personalisation: The Power of Digital Marketing

So, we digested the word digital marketing, and I just told you that digital marketing is not a different kind of marketing. The main goal is still to create value for customers and, in that way, receive value in return. I already provided you with lots of examples, but I would like to share two others to illustrate how fun digital marketing can be.

5.1 Location-Based Advertising

There are a lot of exciting things happening, and one of them is location-based advertising. Here's how it works: instead of traditional ads—let's say a fast-food commercial on TV that reaches everyone, whether they're interested or not—digital marketing allows for real-time, location-based promotions. Imagine you're walking through a shopping mall. Based on past behavior, companies might know that you love discounts, frequently visit certain fast-food chains, and are open to personalized offers. Now, instead of just hoping you'll walk in, they can send you a real-time promotion straight to your phone, saying: "Stop by now and get a free drink with your meal." This kind of personalization is much more targeted and data-driven, and businesses can even track if customers actually respond to these offers.

5.2 Loyalty Programmes

A second example I want to share with you, which is also another great example of personalization, is loyalty programs. Take Delhaize's SuperPlus card, for instance. If you agree to share certain data, they can analyze your shopping habits and give you personalized discounts and recommendations. In other words, the technology works in the background to tailor offers that fit your preferences—as long as you're comfortable with sharing that information, of course.

Let's take a closer look at personalization. It sounds great, right? It offers a lot of benefits—for businesses and customers alike. But at the same time, it also raises some important concerns, particularly when it comes to privacy. So, where do we draw the line? This is actually something we refer to as a paradox—both in academic literature and in practice. On one hand, people appreciate relevant, personalized experiences. They don't want to be bombarded with ads or offers that don't interest them. But on the other hand, there's often this uneasy feeling—the idea that companies might be collecting too much data about them. That's what the privacy versus personalization paradox is about.

That's why businesses need to be transparent about how and why they use data. Take the example of Delhaize's loyalty card. Customers can choose to share their data in exchange for

personalized offers. But they're also made aware that in order to receive these benefits, they need to provide certain information. It's about giving customers control over their own data.

And, of course, regulations like the GDPR in the EU play an important role here. These laws ensure that companies can't just collect and use personal data however they want. We've all seen those cookie pop-ups asking us to accept or reject tracking. And while they might seem annoying, they actually help increase awareness around data privacy.

So, for marketers, the key takeaway is this: personalization has huge potential, but it comes with responsibilities. Customers need to be clearly informed about what's happening with their data. Not just because it's legally required, but because honesty and transparency build trust. And ultimately, that's what good marketing—and good business—is all about.

6. Why Is Digital Marketing Such a Hot Topic?

Digital marketing seems to be a hot topic. It seems as if it is everywhere these days. You see it in courses, workshops, webinars—everyone promises to teach you the latest and greatest trends. But what makes digital marketing such a hot topic right now?

Well, first of all, there's just a lot happening in the digital space. Think about it—drones, chatbots, blockchain, advanced analytics... So many innovations are emerging at the same time. And businesses don't just want to keep up with these trends; they want to get better at using them. Take service robots, for example. They're already being used in healthcare settings, like elderly care homes. These robots can provide companionship, play games with residents, even remind them about phone calls they made yesterday—"Hey, how was your chat with your son?" They can also monitor if someone has gotten out of bed or, in the case of dementia patients, if they've wandered off.

And here's the thing—these technologies aren't just becoming more advanced, they're also becoming cheaper. A robot like Nao, which was super expensive five years ago, is now much more affordable. This combination of increasing capabilities and decreasing costs makes it really attractive for businesses to invest in digital solutions. That's why we're seeing such a boom in digital marketing, technologies that are able to do more and are less expensive.

6.2 A Fourth Industrial Revolution

You might be thinking... this isn't new. And yeah, it's true—this isn't the first time new technology has entered our lives. Back in the day, if you wanted a movie ticket, you had to stand in line and interact with a real person. Then, self-service kiosks came along, and suddenly, that whole experience looked very different. But somehow, this time, it feels different. For the first time, we're seeing so many new technologies emerging all at once—and at an insane pace. It's no coincidence that the World Economic Forum talk about a fourth industrial revolution. Because we're not talking about just one new technology; we're talking about a whole wave of them, all being rolled out at lightning speed. And on top of that, they just keep

getting better... and cheaper.

6.3 Impact on Workers

And of course, all these technologies are having a big impact on the role of workers, too.

I think this is a good moment to let these first insights sink in with a little musical break. First, I'll let you listen—then I'll explain why I chose this song.

■ *1st Musical Break — Novastar: The Best Is Yet to Come* ■

7. Business Mindset Toward Digital Marketing

That was Novastar with The Best Is Yet to Come. Think back to what I was just talking about. We're not just seeing a lot of new technologies emerging—they're also getting better and better. It really feels like the best is yet to come. But at the same time, we have to ask ourselves: What exactly is the best? Are better technologies always better for us as humans? Will they also be better for employees, for customers... are we talking about real value here? Anyway, this song felt pretty fitting.

You might wonder: are business people really into digital marketing? Are they truly bitten by the digital bug? Before Covid, many companies probably thought, yeah, someday we should do something with digital... maybe give it a try. Maybe we'll make it possible for customers to order online through our website. Maybe we'll develop an app for them. But during—and especially after—Covid, companies started realizing that if they want to survive and keep growing, they simply can't ignore digital tools anymore. And that's why we see a much stronger digital mindset in businesses today. There's a real awareness now. People understand that things are changing fast, and they're much more open to experimenting. Like I mentioned earlier, this is an exciting time, because it's not just that there are more technologies available—these technologies are also becoming more powerful and more affordable. Take service robots, drones, or chatbots, for example. Today, they can do so much more than they could five years ago, and they're getting cheaper too. Of course, experimenting with new technology doesn't mean just trying things randomly. You always need to ask yourself: Who are my customers? What do they need? Is this new technology actually relevant for them? If you think it is, don't go all in right away. Start small. Try a pilot project first. Rent a robot, for instance, don't buy one immediately. See how it goes. Observe how customers react. Do a little research. And then decide if you want to fully implement it.

8. Digital Marketing vs. Traditional Marketing

Another important question we need to ask ourselves: Does digital marketing mean we should completely abandon traditional marketing? Should we just throw those classic marketing textbooks out the window? Well... probably not. Let's take a look at Philip Kotler—often called

the father of modern marketing and one of the key thinkers behind the field. In one of his books, Kotler explains that digital marketing doesn't replace traditional marketing; instead, it enhances it.

Let's zoom in on, say, the P of Promotion. There's a lot you can do in this area. Think about SEO—Search Engine Optimization. You can optimize your website so customers can find your product more easily. Plus, you can run all kinds of analytics: tweak your website, test different versions, and see which one performs best. You can analyze search terms to figure out what's driving traffic to your site. Or take social influencers, for example. They might be close to the audience you're trying to reach, and they can create a direct connection between your brand and potential customers. But that doesn't mean traditional marketing is disappearing completely. Think about it—maybe you still enjoy flipping through a magazine and seeing an ad. Or when you're in a store, maybe you appreciate having a conversation with a salesperson who gives you advice and, with a big smile, promotes the product in a personal way. Some customers prefer digital, others stick to traditional methods, and then there's a group that's open to both. It all depends on the kind of business you run and the value you want to deliver to your customers. In the end, it all comes down to the same thing: today's digital tools simply give you more options. You can do much more in terms of the P of Promotion—but that doesn't mean traditional promotion is going away.

9. Augmented Intelligence: Humans + Machines

So, we have all these digital tools, but we also have real people—flesh and blood. How do they work together? A key term in this discussion is collaborative or augmented intelligence. What does that mean? Well, it's all about humans and digital tools working together. Instead of humans versus machines, it's humans plus machines. Technology isn't replacing human intelligence; it's enhancing or augmenting it.

9.1 Real-World Examples

We can see some great examples of this in practice. Take a doctor who wants to give patients the best possible experience. In the old model, they would probably use some basic technology, but most of the time, they'd be stuck behind a computer, typing in information, staring at the screen. But today? That same doctor could wear augmented reality glasses that project all the necessary information right in their field of view—so they can focus on the patient instead of a screen. Or imagine everything the patient says being automatically recorded and added to their file. That means less paperwork and more time for real, human interaction.

Another example—think about websites. A simple version might just have a Frequently Asked Questions section where customers can find answers on their own. That way, a company's call center can focus on more complex issues, relying much more on humans so employees. Or it could go a step further with an interactive chatbot, programmed to handle the most common questions. Some customers love browsing FAQs and figuring things out for themselves. Others

just want to ask their question directly—and with technology, they don't have to wait for office hours. They can ask it at 3 AM and still get a response.

The point is, today's digital tools aren't necessarily replacing people. Instead, it's about humans and technology working together—making things smoother, smarter, and more efficient.

Let's talk about another example—hotels. These days, you see more and more service robots in hotels. And for some customers, that's totally fine. They're happy to check in through a digital kiosk or ask a robot for basic information. It makes sense—if you just have a simple question, you probably don't want to wait in line at the front desk. But what if something more complex comes up? Say there's a problem with your room. In that case, you might prefer to talk to a real person. That's why hotels divide tasks between humans and machines—some things are handled by technology, while others require human interaction.

The same applies to banks. Some tasks can be taken over by machines entirely, making processes much more efficient. And that frees up employees to focus on what they do best—offering personal service, handling complex issues, and building relationships with customers.

So the whole idea of augmented intelligence is about asking: What can humans do better than machines? And then making sure that people focus their time and energy on those things—the things where human skills really make a difference.

Now, let's shift our focus to the organizational level. At the end of the day, organizations need to go through a digital transformation. So the big question is: What does a company need to make that transformation successful?

You could say, Well, what do you need nowadays? A pandemic, maybe? Something major that forces you to act? Maybe you already had digital plans sitting around, gathering dust at the bottom of the pile. And then suddenly, something happens that makes you pull them out and say, Okay, now we have to do this.

But beyond that, you also need the right mindset.

10.1 Case Study: The Bakery App

Let me give you an example from my own life. There's a bakery on my street that I've been going to for years. But during the pandemic, they decided to go digital. They launched an app where customers could place orders. For me, as a customer, that had a huge advantage—I didn't have to wait in line inside the shop, close to other people.

Another cool thing? The app remembered my previous orders. And since I usually buy the same thing, I could just reorder with one click. Super convenient.

Now, back to the question: What does it take to go through a digital transformation? Sometimes, it takes an external event to push businesses in that direction. The truth is, I would have loved that bakery app before Covid just as much as I did during and after.

And then, of course, there's the digital mindset. That awareness that the world is changing. Just open a newspaper, and you'll see—new technologies are emerging, companies are collecting more data than ever, and advanced analytics are taking things to the next level.

As a company, you might think, My customers don't need all that digital stuff. But what if they're already using apps from your competitors? That's really the key: if you want to transform digitally, you need awareness. Awareness of the possibilities. And also the ability to ask yourself: Are we ready for this? Do we have the right people, the right tools, the right structure to make this transformation happen? And most importantly—never lose sight of who your customers are and what they need.

11. A Positive Perspective on Digital Technology

Something else... Digital marketing is often looked at from a rather negative perspective. Robots will take our jobs. Humans will become irrelevant. Our data is no longer safe. Some technologies don't benefit humanity and won't make the world a better place. But if we only focus on the negatives, we forget that technology also has a beautiful side. In some cases, technology can actually make the world better.

Take, for example, someone in a wheelchair. Imagine giving them a robotic exoskeleton that allows them to walk again. That would be life-changing. Or another example—there's a café in Japan where people with severe disabilities, who wouldn't normally be able to work, can work. How? By remotely controlling robots that serve customers. These employees are lying in bed at home, yet they're still able to be part of the workforce. That's amazing. And it completely challenges the idea that technology is just about taking away jobs. In reality, technology can also create jobs.

This kind of positivity is exactly what augmented or collaborative intelligence can be about. It's not about replacing humans—it's about working together and combining strengths.

At the same time, as people, as employees, we also need to acknowledge something: There are certain tasks that machines simply do better than us. Maybe we need to accept that and just let machines do their thing? Definitely something to think about. And by doing that, we free ourselves up to focus on other things—things that humans are really good at, like creativity or offering a warm, personalized welcome. That's the challenge for organizations today: figuring out what augmented intelligence really means for them.

Now, let's take a moment to let all of this sink in with a second musical intermezzo. I'll let you listen first, and then I'll tell you why I chose this piece.

■ **2nd Musical Break — Emily Howell: Track One (AI-composed)** ■

12. Artificial Intelligence & Creativity

That was Track One, created by Emily Howell. I chose this track very deliberately—because Emily Howell is not a human. It's actually a machine. A bot. Let me quickly explain how this bot works. Basically, it's a program that analyzes all kinds of music that have been created in the past. It studies patterns—Which notes typically follow each other? What types of music exist? How do rhythm, pitch, and melodies come together? And based on all that information, this bot was able to compose its own piece of music.

Now, here's where it gets really interesting—the Alan Turing Test. Alan Turing is often considered the godfather of artificial intelligence. He's best known for his famous Turing Test. And what does that test say? Well, imagine you have two pieces of music. One is composed by a human, the other by a machine—like this bot. Now, you play them for a group of people and ask: Which one do you think was created by a human? And which one by a machine? If people can't tell the difference, then the AI has passed the Turing Test. In other words, this track has successfully fooled human listeners. And that's exactly what makes this so relevant. It perfectly illustrates what technology is capable of today. Like I mentioned earlier—technology keeps improving. To the point where we can no longer tell if something was made by a human or by a machine.

Imagine you're passionate about digital marketing and you have the ambition to really make an impact in that field. So, what do you need?

13.1 The Ikigai Principle

One great framework to lean on is the Ikigai principle—which really applies to many areas of life. There are four key questions to consider: First, what do you love doing? Second, what are you good at? (And those two might not always overlap.) Third, what does the world need? And fourth, is there a willingness to pay for it? Now, applied to digital marketing, ask yourself: What is it that you love doing? Do you enjoy diving into data and analysis? Are you the type who loves exploring new apps, or perhaps you're keen on discovering innovative business models? Maybe you're all about understanding who your customers are and figuring out which tools to implement first? And, of course, you need to consider whether you're really good at all of that. On top of that, reflect on whether the world—or more specifically, your customers—actually needs it. For example, if you're thinking about introducing a chatbot or an app, is that really important to your customers? And will they be willing to pay for it, that could be with money but for instance also by sharing personal data? So, what does it take to be a digital marketer? It all boils down to those four questions from the Ikigai principle.

But beyond that, it's crucial to be extremely flexible and willing to embrace change. As a digital marketer, you need that agility. We saw this clearly during Covid. If you're a digital marketer—or aspire to be one—you absolutely must be adaptable. Only those who adjust to change will thrive. In line with this skill, it's also important that you enjoy lifelong learning. Because, yes, there will always be new technologies emerging, new analytics techniques, different types of data to analyze, and so on...

And yes, you also need to be a team player as a digital marketer. You must be able to collaborate with others. For example, if you look at smart products today, you'll see that a lot of different parties need to come together. You have the app developer, the supermarket, and so on. There are many different stakeholders in digital marketing working together to deliver value to customers. So, you need to enjoy such challenges.

With that being said, it's time to wrap up this podcast. I hope this short podcast has sparked your interest in digital marketing. I'd like to end with three key takeaways. First, we need to acknowledge that digital marketing is here to stay. We can no longer ignore it. Whether we like it or not, we'll have to deal with it. Second: what does this mean for marketers? Well, there are two main points. First, new business models are emerging because of new technologies like drones, robots, and smart products. And second, data. We have access to more data than ever before, which gives us deeper insights and allows us to connect with customers on a more personalized level. And third, you need to get started as an organization. Just take that first step, no matter how small. Start experimenting and playing around with it. Don't wait until the train has passed you by.

With that, I want to thank you for your attention, and wish you a wonderful day ahead.